



financial compensation when entering coaching at the youth and developmental levels, especially after an elite athletic career, can be financially and emotionally challenging for coaches. Many don't fully understand their mindset — whether they see themselves as good enough in their new role as a coach, after having been among the best as an athlete.

The knowledge we have about the athlete-to-coach transition is somewhat skewed, as it largely comes from a few countries and a few professional, high-performance sports. For instance, we also don't know much about the transition for the many non-elite athletes who get invited or volunteer to coach. A good coach does not necessarily have to have been a good player, and vice versa. There are few exceptions in the world who have been world-beaters both as players and as coaches — many of them found in football, athletics, hockey, cricket, badminton, and so on.

Recent research on elite athletes transitioning into coaching reveals how challenging it is to go from being the flower — with all attention

focused on them — to becoming the gardener who cares for others. Research has shown that to move from *Me* to *We*, one must let go of the elite identity, ego, and mindset — something that is neither an overnight transformation nor an effortless shift.

Apart from their identities, retired elite athletes-turned-coaches often carry with them the methods of their former coaches, sometimes even perpetuating the same abuse they experienced as athletes. Even for those with formal coach education, the shift in identity, mindset, and practice from their playing days remains a significant challenge.

The transition from athlete to coach entails exiting the known, accepting the unknown and uncertain, and ultimately developing a new system tailored to the team's culture and needs. In this process, coach education, development, and support can serve as a starting point. Having the right support staff is also key to a coach's success. Else, it can lead to injuries and misleading narratives about the team, often aimed at safeguarding contracts.

Many coaches are unaware of the

The right fit: Gautam Gambhir and Rahul Dravid, the current and former coaches of the Indian men's cricket team, had outstandingly successful careers as players. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

pitfalls that an incompetent physio or strength and conditioning (S&C) coach can create. I have seen, many times, players getting injured at crucial moments and being short charged due to the support staff's lack of knowledge.

In some cases, support staff are brought in based on player recommendations, which can seriously damage the team's entire ecosystem. **Coaches must be vigilant when selecting the right professionals, doing their due diligence on each member of the support staff.**

To avoid the above-mentioned issues, coaches need to educate themselves in the process — identifying the weak links in the team and hiring a robust team to pursue world titles. New toolboxes must be created to suit each coach's philosophy and approach — which is a no-brainer.